

Hardware303

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I have implemented a partial replica of the Roland TB-303 in VHDL. The Roland TB-303 is an analog bass line synthesizer noted for its characteristic filter - a diode ladder filter - that is hard to replicate in software. This design uses a Moog ladder filter however, since it is much more well known, and does not require significant analog analysis to replicate the sound of the TB-303 as a diode ladder would.

Theory of Operation

Basic Blocks

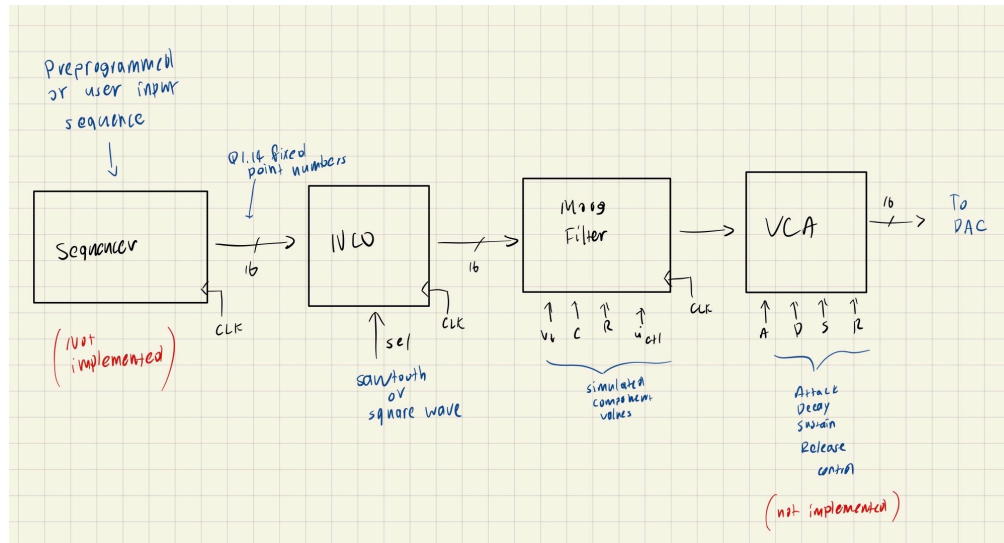


Figure 1: Hardware 303 Block diagram

The Roland TB-303 consists of the following blocks: - Oscillator: a voltage-controlled oscillator that creates a square or sawtooth wave in the bass clef range. - Filter: a resonant low-pass filter meant to mimic the sound of a Moog ladder filter, but using diodes instead of BJTs for the active component of the filter. - Sequencer: a small bank of memory and logic that generates the frequencies to be produced by the oscillator. - VCA: a voltage controlled amplifier used to control the dynamics (volume before, during, and after a note is played). The TB-303 has the controls of ADSR (attack, decay, sustain, and release).

Thus, the Hardware 303 should implement the digital equivalent of each of these blocks. That is,

- A numerically controlled oscillator that takes an integer and produces both a square and sawtooth wave of the desired frequency.
- A Moog ladder filter that models the dynamics of the analog filter.
- A sequencer that generates integers according to a user input pattern.
- A NCA (numerically controlled amplifier) that prescales the output according to the desired setting.

In this project, an NCO and filter were implemented and tested in VHDL.

NCO

An NCO capable of outputting a square and sawtooth wave essentially consists of an adder, a comparator, and a few registers to accumulate the added value. The input word is added each clock period, and if a

sawtooth waveform is desired, we just output the accumulated value. If a square wave output is desired, we simply threshold the accumulated value according to our desired duty cycle. More complex NCOs included phase control word inputs in addition to frequency control inputs, allowing the user to shift the phase when desired. If a sine wave is desired, a lookup table mapping an accumulated value to an output value can be implemented.

The NCO was tested over the bass clef range by logging the output word at each clock cycle to a text file. This text file was then analyzed with a Python script, `verify_nco.py`. This generates both a time and frequency domain plot for each output frequency. We also programmitically verify that besides just the fundamental frequency being correct, the spectral contents of the waveform are what we expect for a square and sawtooth wave. A perfect square wave will contain only odd harmonics, while a sawtooth wave will include all harmonics. The harmonics of both will decay at a rate of 6dB / octave.

Filter

A resonant low-pass filter is simply a low-pass filter that produces The filter is based on the Huovilainen's paper titled "NON-LINEAR DIGITAL IMPLEMENTATION OF THE MOOG LADDER FILTER" [1], in which the author aproximates the non-linearities of a Moog ladder filter, resulting in the following input-output equations:

$$\begin{aligned}
 y_a(n) &= y_a(n-1) + \frac{I_{ctl}}{CF_s} \left(\tanh \left(\frac{x(n) - 4ry_d(n-1)}{2V_t} \right) - W_a(n-1) \right) \\
 y_b(n) &= y_b(n-1) + \frac{I_{ctl}}{CF_s} (W_a(n) - W_b(n-1)) \\
 y_c(n) &= y_c(n-1) + \frac{I_{ctl}}{CF_s} (W_b(n) - W_c(n-1)) \\
 y_d(n) &= y_d(n-1) + \frac{I_{ctl}}{CF_s} \left(W_c(n) - \tanh \left(\frac{y_d(n-1)}{2V_t} \right) \right) \\
 W_{\{a,b,c\}}(n) &= \tanh \left(\frac{y_{\{a,b,c\}}(n)}{2V_t} \right)
 \end{aligned}$$

where $x[n]$ is the output of NCO, and y_d is the output of the filter. We naturally see that this design lends itself to a multistage design, in which we can generically define a filter stage, as well as a generic "W block" that computes $W_{\{a,b,c\}}(n)$.

The W block can be represented as follows:

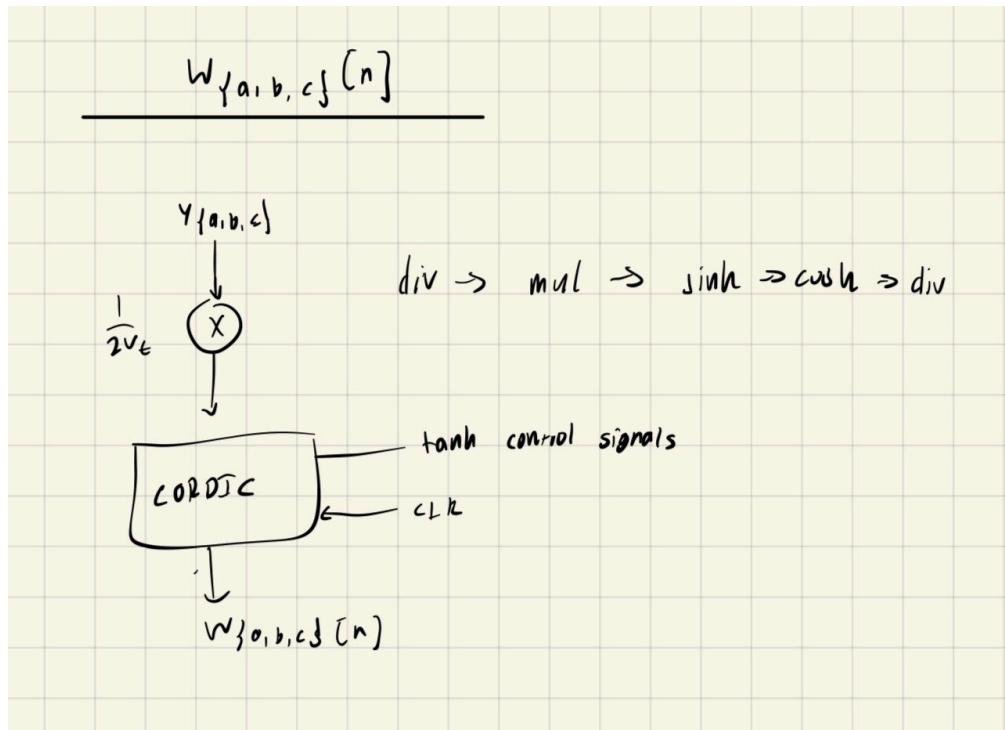


Figure 2: W block diagram

Pratically, we implement division and mulitplication with the CORDIC as well. Additionally, since the CORDIC can only calculate sinh, and cosh, we need a final division step to calculate tanh. This can be done with the following arrangement of CORDICs:

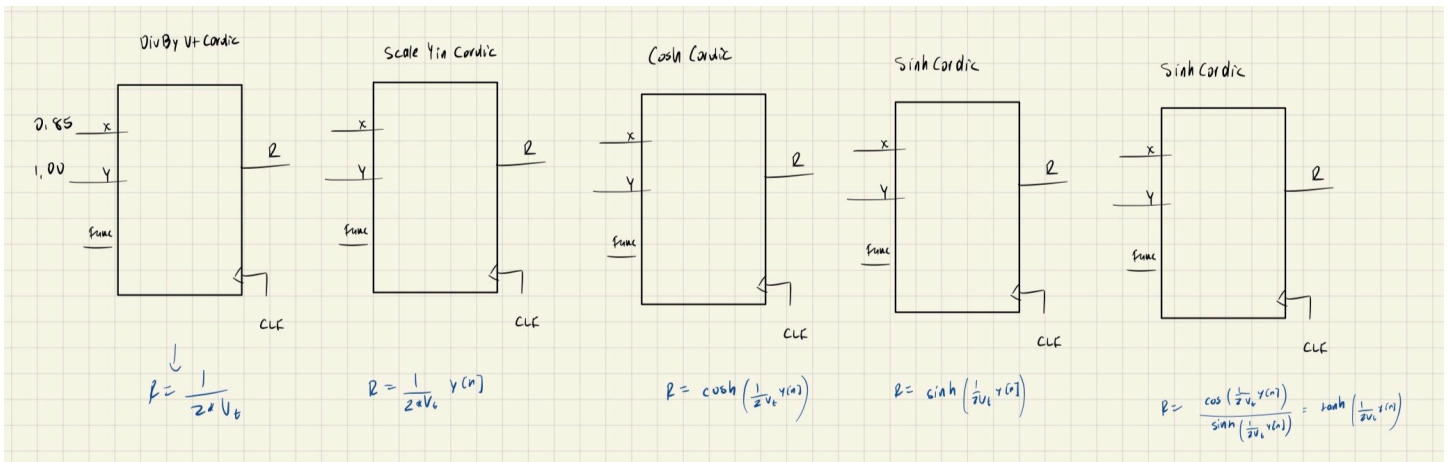


Figure 3: W block digital diagram

It is important to note that the finished design uses Q1.14 signed fixed point numbers (or Q2.14 depending on the naming) convention. This means that we have two bits for a signed integer part, and 14 bits for the fractional part. This was done because the CORDIC was rigorously tested in this configuration, but this severely limits range of intermediate values we can represent. Ideally, we would be able to represent the voltage range of original TB-303, which is most on the order of 10s of voltages.

Additionally, the CORDIC was modified so that multiple instantiations of it are possible, and was made fully concurrent to simplify prototyping. This will severely limit speed, but since our timing requirement is relatively large, we are okay with this trade off.

The filter as a whole can be represented using the following diagram.

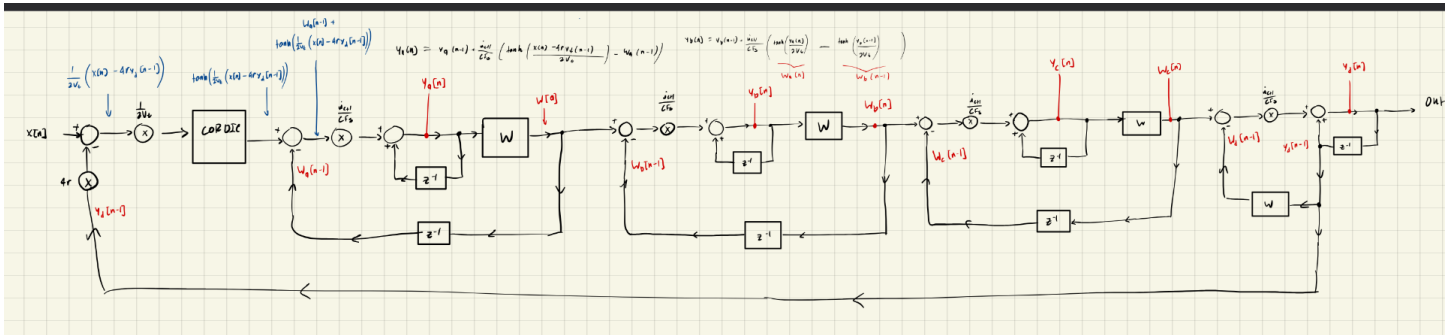


Figure 4: Moof filter diagram

Results

The NCO was shown to accurately produce the required notes in the bass clef.

Source Code structure

```
./
├─ Dockerfile # dockerfile used for reproducible github build (doesn't work currently)
├─ Makefile # top level makefile (doesn't work currently)
├─ README.md
├─ TODO.md
├─ build_osvvm.sh # osvvm build script
├─ cordic/
│   # cordic directory. Note that this includes many versions of the cordic
│   # also note that these versions are BROKEN (you can't instantiate multiple
│   # of them because I have a shared variable bug in the CordicConstants package)
├─ doc.md # project documentation source code
├─ doc.pdf # project documentation PDF
├─ filter/ # filter implementation. Includes all relevant files
│   ├── AddSub.vhd* # 1-bit adder/subtractor
│   ├── AdderSubtractor.vhd* # n-bit adder/subtractor
│   ├── AnsiEscape.vhd* # AnsiEscape constants for colored output
│   ├── Cordic.vhd* # 16-bit, Q1.14 (signed) fixed point cordic. Implemented internally
│   | # using Q3.18 signed fixed point numbers (22-bit). Modified to be
│   | # concurrent. Implemented using multiple stages
│   ├── CordicStage.vhd* # A single Cordic stage
│   └─ FixedLib.vhd* # Real to fixed point standard_logic_vector conversion and vice-versa
├─ Makefile # filter make file
├─ MoogFilter.vhd # Top level filter source file
├─ MoogFilterStage.vhd # A single stage of the moog ladder filter
├─ MoogFilterStage_TB.vhd # Test bench for single moog ladder filter stage
├─ MoogFilter_TB.vhd # test bench for top level moog ladder filter
├─ WBlock.vhd # W block source file (see above)
└─ WBlock_TB.vhd # W block test bench
```

```

|   |─ make_filter.sh*           # shell script to build and run the filter
|   |─ make_stage.sh*          # shell script to build and run the filter stage test bench
|   |─ matlab/                 # matlab dev files
|   |─ moogfilterstage_conf.gtkw
|   |─ moogfilterstage_tb.vcd
|   |─ out.txt
|   |─ q1_14_filter.py*        # GTKwave filter to show fixed point numbers
|   |─ work/
|─ filter_diagram.jpg
|─ gcc-12.5.0/                 # GCC source code (for compiling GHDL 7.0.0 from source)
|
|─ nco/
|   |─ INSTRUCTIONS.md         # build instructions
|   |─ Makefile*               # makefile
|   |─ nco.vhd*                # NCO source file
|   |─ nco_tb.vhd*             # NCO test bench
|   |─ out.txt                  # output words from test bench
|   |─ sawtooth.txt             # sawtooth only output words
|   |─ sawtooth_freq_domain/    # frequency domain plots
|   |─ sawtooth_time_domain/    # time domain plots
|   |─ square.txt               # square wave only output words
|   |─ square_freq_domain/      # frequency domain plots
|   |─ square_time_domain/      # time domain plots
|   |─ time_util.vhd            # ???
|   |─ verify_nco.py*           # iterations of python script used to verify NCO
|   |─ verify_nco.py.copy*
|   |─ verify_nco_1.py
|   |─ verify_nco_2.py
|   |─ verify_nco_3.py
|─ sub.md                      # submission doc
|─ w_block.jpg
|─ w_block_digital.jpg

```

Building

Ideally:

```

$ cd filter
$ ./make_filter.sh

```

but this will most likely not work for others because

- 1) I used GHDL 7.0.0 (compiled from source), which has breaking changes when compared to versions of GHDL packages with distros
- 2) My OSVVM build directory is hard coded there

I am working on getting it to build in github.

[1] https://dafx.de/paper-archive/2004/P_061.PDF